Before you pay a hospital bill

A first bill usually shows only totals. Take these steps in order. In one national survey, about three in four people who called about a bill they believed was wrong got it corrected.

- [ ] Wait for your plan's explanation of benefits, which comes after the plan processes the claim. Pay nothing before it arrives.
- [ ] Ask the billing office for the itemized statement: for each charge, the CPT or HCPCS code, the revenue code, the quantity and the price. **itemized-bill.txt**
- [ ] Match the statement against the explanation of benefits, line by line. Look for anything billed twice and for codes that don't fit the service. **prompt-bill.txt**
- [ ] Ask for the financial assistance policy. Every nonprofit hospital has one, and you can apply up to 240 days after the first bill. Extraordinary collection actions stop while a complete application is under review. **financial-assistance.txt**
- [ ] If you paid for the care yourself and the bill runs more than $400 over your good-faith estimate, write to the billing office. The federal dispute process takes cases up to 120 days after the bill. **estimate-dispute.txt**
- [ ] If a collector writes about a debt you don't recognize, dispute it in writing before the validation period on the notice runs out. **debt-validation.txt**
- [ ] Send everything through a portal, email or certified mail, so the date is on record. Keep a copy, and follow up in two weeks if nothing comes back.

General information about how health care works, not medical or legal advice. Nothing here should delay care in an emergency. The letters named here are free at healthusersguide.com.